recorded at 34.5 per cent and 18.3 per cent, respectively, in rural and urban areas. Combined LPR was 45.8 per cent in rural areas and 37.2 per cent in urban areas.

LPR has gradually declined from this level in the late 1970s. By 1999–2000, LPR for rural areas had declined to 42.3 per cent and 35.4 per cent for urban areas, a decline of about 3 per cent in rural areas and 2 per cent in urban areas. The decline in female LPR was more pronounced, falling by 4.1 per cent in rural areas to 30.2 per cent and by 3.6 per cent in urban areas to 30.2 per cent and 14.7 per cent, respectively.

GDP has been rising continuously, at a much higher rate in the 1980s and 1990s, indicating the expansion of economic activities. However, LPR has been declining. While this indicated an improvement in productivity, the potential of the economy to absorb labour was going down.

Women's Participation in Labour Force One of the Lowest in the World

In 2020, the global participation of women in the labour force (women who are either working or unemployed but seeking work) represented by female LPR was 46.9 per cent, as per the database maintained by ILO/World Bank. India's female LPR is merely 20.2 per cent. This means that only one in five women in the working age of over fifteen participates in the labour force. There are only a handful of countries—Algeria, Syria, Yemen and a few other Arab countries—that have a female LPR lower than India.

Indeed, female LPR in India has been declining significantly in the past fifteen years. From a peak of 31.9 per cent in 2005, it declined rapidly to 22.8 per cent in 2012. It has continued to decline thereafter, although at a slightly lower rate.

How long and to what level will LPR decline in India? Will we attain the dubious distinction of being the worst country where women do not work in the economy? Why have we confined our women to their homes?